



ON THE RECORD

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SOME THANK YOUS

To Kaustubh & the Samagata team—you have built a third space so meaningful.

To Abhishek, Aishani, Artika, Akshay, & Srijoni—you anchored this space and guided us with honest, actionable feedback.

To everyone who showed on a Friday night & participated with genuine curiosity—we're beyond grateful for your time, work, and perspective. Thank you for caring.

On the Record

OutLawed India trains and deploys Paralegal Volunteers (PLVs) who help people access legal aid, in partnership with the Karnataka State Legal Services Authority (KSLSA) as well as independently. This work has produced an enormous amount of data not only regarding our interventions, but also regarding institutions and people delivering legal-aid.

On the Record (OTR) emerged as an initiative centred around opening the data and programme up to peer-review so it can be tested, questioned, and used more broadly by the legal aid sector.

The first edition was held on 19 June 2026 in Bangalore. Around 40 participants, consisting of researchers, lawyers, policy practitioners, and data analysts, spent 2.5 hours in small groups, each examining PLV data from a different region of Karnataka. Groups worked independently, without heavy direction, and were simply asked: what stands out, does it match what you'd expect, what could this inform, and what else is worth flagging. Follow-up conversations with each group afterward deepened the findings below.

This following segment synthesises those findings into three core narratives, and also frames ecosystem-level takeaways from the same.

Case Study

For the first edition of OTR, attendees pored over data that OutLawed India collected through its design and training of PLVs across 24 districts of Karnataka. This data included

1. PLV Quant: data from trainee PLVs on learning outcomes and demography
2. PLV Qual: data from trainee PLVs on motivations, community legal issues, perceptions of law and justice
3. Institutional Quant: data from authorities on previous legal-aid interventions, utilisation of PLVs
4. Institutional Qual: data from authorities on perception of PLVs, recommendations for improvement

Reading the Findings Together

Core Insight 1: Identity Crisis of PLVs

PLV work is layered on top of existing jobs, not separate from them. A large share of PLVs are already ASHA workers, Anganwadi workers, or teachers. This means most PLVs were likely doing community work formally and informally before the programme gave it a name. This adds to an already heavy workload, largely carried by women, without any corresponding reduction in their other duties. Women make up roughly two-thirds of PLVs overall, though participation varied sharply by district depending on how much structured outreach happened there.

No institution agrees on what a PLV actually is. DLSAs (District Legal Services Authorities) tend to see PLVs as an extension of the formal legal system. PLVs themselves describe their work more in the language of social work : legal knowledge as one tool among many, not a professional identity. This mismatch also splits by background: PLVs who come from a law background lean toward formal legal aid and awareness-building, while community-recruited PLVs lean toward direct, practical action. The programme currently has no way of routing each group toward the work they're best suited for.

Where the system worked, it works because of motivated individuals, not structural design. In districts with strong outcomes, it's typically because a specific official chose to actively engage with PLVs, not because of any process that would guarantee the same elsewhere. Judges who serve as DLSA administrators often lack the support to manage this well, and no one is clearly responsible for monitoring PLVs once training ends. Given the multiple identities of PLVs, there's also a lack of a single administrator who is responsible.

Ecosystem takeaway: This is a pattern seen well beyond PLVs. New frontline justice or welfare roles tend to default to recruiting from the same pool of already-overburdened community women (ASHA/Anganwadi workers). Any organisation building a similar role should ask, before recruiting: whose existing labour is this new title sitting on top of? And when one person holds multiple frontline titles, no single system currently accounts for the added administrative burden of navigating separate reporting lines, paperwork, and expectations across departments that don't talk to each other.

Core Insight 2: Making PLVs Actually Work on the Ground

Deployment is informal and inconsistent. Recommendations from the discussions included: deploying PLVs strategically into courts and police stations rather than leaving it ad hoc; building structured coordination between PLVs and local police (e.g. a police liaison at every courthouse) to reduce PLVs' hesitation around bureaucracy; and creating frameworks that carry PLVs from *knowing* the law to *practising* its procedures. While ensuring such practice, it was also observed that most PLVs in their surveys covered a wide range of issues they'd like to work on—but notably identity-centred legal issues (caste, religion, region) were missing from the same.

Compensation is inconsistent and poorly tracked. Stipend structures vary widely by district. Many DLSAs don't have a clear process for budgeting PLV compensation at all, some PLVs were not even sure if they're paid for training days. There's also a subtler risk: incentive structures can unintentionally push PLVs toward easier, more "rewarded" cases and away from harder, less incentivised ones: so incentive *design*, not just size, matters.

Training is improving but still too short and too broad. This year's longer training cycle was seen as an improvement, but two issues recur: training tries to cover too many topics at once (diluting focus), and four days isn't enough: with no structured follow-up afterward. Suggestions included more targeted, locally customised curricula; refresher sessions; a support helpline; cross-learning with other frontline cadres facing similar pressures; and building emotional/motivational engagement before diving into technical legal content. One thing training does succeed at: PLVs increasingly describe welfare schemes as *rights* rather than favours, and see their PLV identity as a kind of shield that changes how they navigate intimidating interactions with police and administration.

Ecosystem takeaway: Intermediary roles like PLVs are created to bridge communities and institutions, but the institutions on the other side rarely have a defined, reciprocal role in supporting them. The intermediary is left to navigate bureaucracy and escalate problems mostly on their own, with success depending entirely on whether one official happens to be responsive. Fixing this means building standing coordination structures (not relying on individual champions), giving intermediaries a clear escalation/protection pathway, and designing multi-actor coordination between institutions from the start, rather than making the intermediary the only one responsible for translating between systems.

Core Insight 3: Bridging the “Formal” and the “Informal”

Training has visibly shifted DLSA officials' views of PLVs, from real skepticism beforehand to much more confidence afterward. But that shift in *belief* hasn't reliably translated into a shift in *practice*. The single strongest predictor of PLV success in the data is how engaged the local official happens to be; not any institutional standard. Word-of-mouth is still the main way PLVs learn about the programme in many districts, which leaves many feeling isolated when they do need to navigate authorities on their own.

Notable district-level patterns (illustrating how much outcomes vary by local context):

- Districts with strong outreach saw far higher PLV enrollment than others.
- One district's strong performance in child-protection casework was traced to a single highly engaged official: a positive result, but a fragile one, since it depended on one person rather than any system.
- A district with almost no structured outreach had very low female PLV participation.
- A district where most PLVs were already retirees or social workers raised questions about how much formal training actually adds for that group.
- A couple of districts saw confidence scores drop *after* training, possibly linked to PLVs rarely or never being deployed.
- Districts with higher concentrations of law-student PLVs, or higher local lawyer density, tended to see better outcomes overall.

Ecosystem takeaway: There's an unresolved tension between treating this kind of work as "social work" versus as "an extension of the formal legal system", and it shows up anywhere community justice models are built in India. The fix isn't more training; it's a shared, cross-organisational framework defining scope and expectations for these roles, similar to how ASHA workers eventually got a defined scope of practice after years of ambiguity. When success depends on one engaged individual rather than structural design, that's a governance risk, not a success story.

What's Next: Ecosystem Opportunities

A few ideas emerged directly from OTR discussions:

1. **A cross-organisational Data & M&E Review Board:** a formal group where organisations review each other's survey tools, methodologies, and programme models before they're implemented, strengthening rigor across the sector.
2. **A shared, public repository for legal aid insights:** where organisations voluntarily contribute research and insight, building a common evidence base for the sector. This would focus on not just data but replicable learnings and insights for others looking to build as well.
3. **A stronger support system for frontline workers:** addressing how PLVs (and similar frontline roles) are compensated, motivated, and connected to other state actors they interact with, such as POCSO Support Persons and Juvenile Justice institutions.

OTR itself is expanding: future editions won't be limited to OutLawed India's own data, or maybe even to data at all. The space is opening up to any organisation that wants peer review on programme design, research, or system design more broadly. OutLawed India's role going forward is to facilitate: designing and running the workshop, curating groups, and handling logistics, so presenting organisations can focus on the questions they want the room to engage with.

Interested organisations can express interest via this [form](#) or by writing to us at contact@outlawedindia.com.

STEAL OUR ICE-BREAKER



You'll need: straws, tape/strings, table tennis ball, fun people

Instructions: teams have 5 minutes to assemble a structure using straws and the tape/string. the tallest structure that balances the table tennis ball at the top wins!